**MEMORANDUM**

**TO:** John Chin
**FROM:** Xocas Álvarez-Jorge
**DATE:** December 12, 2024
**RE:** Review of *Living the Asian Century: An Undiplomatic Memoir* by Kishore Mahbubani

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## Executive Summary

*Kishore Mahbubani's life serves as a metaphor and surrogate of Asia's wider generational rise. Not unlike many Asian states, Kishore details his life. A meteoritic rise from poverty to success, but one frustrated by those more powerful than him, resulting in friction. Kishore had gone from a perceived inferiority complex about Asian backwardness to a renewed confidence and power in his culture and background. This book explores his life (and by extension that of Singapore) from a mainly diplomatic perspective.*

*This book is important for diplomats since one can learn from Kishore's experience and mistakes, and use them to further advance their career. This review shows that Kishore's contributions with his book revolve around how his networking and interpersonal relations was critical in his success, but also career limitations. Aside from this, the memoir serves as a different perspective to diplomatic affairs that diplomats, especially western based ones like ourselves, can do much to learn about. Throughout the book Kishore explains the disconnect between Western Powers and Asian (and more broadly third world countries), calling into question western diplomatic frameworks and understandings.*

## I. Organization and Diplomatic Content

### A. Memoir Structure

Mahbubani organizes his memoir in a roughly chronological manner, but this is subject to exploring the main themes of the book and his intellectual development. Chronologically, this memoir can be divided into three rough parts.

- **First Movement (1948-1984): Formative Years**
  - British colonial childhood
  - Singapore's independence journey
  - University Journy
  - Early diplomatic postings in Cambodia and Malaysia
- **Second Movement (1984-2004): Peak Diplomatic Career**
  - UN ambassadorship
  - Security Council presidency
  - Height of traditional diplomatic influence
  - Major multilateral negotiations and initiatives
- **Third Movement (2004-2019): Thought Leadership**

- Transition from practitioner to public intellectual
- Dean of the Lee Kuan Yew School of Public Policy
- Shaping global discourse about the Asian Century
- Influence through ideas rather than official position

This chronological structure weaves and alternates three main themes together: Geopolitical analysis/comentary, Diplomatic episodes and Mahbubani's personal narration and growth. This makes it difficult to separate or isolate any single part as belonging to diplomacy (potentially aside from the early childhood section). Kishores unique upbringing and personality enabaled his diplomatic career, just as his career shaped him.

### B. Key Diplomatic Episodes

Mahbubani's early posting to Cambodia during the Khmer Rouge period was his first and quite literal "baptism by fire", where he nearly lost his life in shelling by the Khmer Rouge. Such an episode marks a transition from his initial political idealism to later shift to realism. The inaction, and even aggravation of the situation by the international community (that is primarily the United States) was for him strange,marking the start of his move to a more "realist" world view.

His UN years align very much with the core of our class and what we have learned in Diplomacy and Statecraft. These years outline his most formative growth and insights in the realm of diplomacy and where he reached maturity as a diplomat. Mahbubani discusses his experiences requiring the intricate act of aligning p5 nations with the interests of Singapore but also Asean in the UN and diplomatic arena.

Concurrently, Mahbubani outlines his realization the realist nature of the UN, that is the all the major power work the weaken the UN as an institution. Mahbubani Particularly calls out what he perceives to be the hypocrisy of western states in terms of lending vocal support to the UN, but in action undermining it. For Mahbubani and Singapore, this power imbalance of different understanding of the UN served as a challenge for him. However, Mahbubani is able to overcome this, through consensus building, leveraging personal relations and compromising. This provides several insights for aspiring diplomatic, foremost was the importance of cultivating individual friendships.

The third and final section of the memoir discusses Mahbubani's contributions to diplomacy outside traditional diplomacy. Mahbubani, earlier sections discuss his fading diplomatic career and transition to an intellectual figure. Mahbubani's early childhood had started with a passion for reading and later interest in academia, which he later rekindled after his diplomatic career. Also rekinelded was his initial idealism, this time instead informed by the realist tint he had achieved from working for the government and diplomatic service. As the founding dean of the Lee Kuan Yew school of public policy, the later section of his memories was more reflective over his diplomatic experiences, moving past from the tactics of diplomacy to broader strategy. Here Mahbubani discuses trends and movements in geopolitics and diplomacy as a whole, where he discusses Asians rise and an east-west "convergence". However, Mahbubani still leverages his academic position for diplomatic purposes through track two diplomacy.

## II. Lessons from Diplomatic Experience

### A. Achievements

- *Small state diplomacy: Mahbubani leverages intellectual capital over military/economic power*

- *Mahbubani builds bridges between western and asian states, balancing interests and consultations]*
- *Multilateral engagement: Mahubani's usage of ASEAn and the UN to advance Singaporean interests highlights the need for consolation across various powers*

### B. Challenges and Failures

- *Mahbubani's hubris: His own personal undiplomatic honesty, arrogance and hubris cost him his career ultimately*
- *While successful, Mahbubani still faced limitations as a representative for a tiny state. Singapore could only accomplish so much.*

### C. Key Insights

- *Importance of consensus building for multi lateral diplomacy*
- *The importance of personal relations for diplomacy*
- *The importance of humility and self-awareness for a diplomatic role*
- *Value of long-term perspective over short-term gains*

## III. Guiding Worldview, Themes and Strategic Concepts

Mahbubani offers a distinct non western approach and philosophy to diplomatic and foreign policy but also to political orientations and understandings. Mahbubani criticizes double standards in western policy and an ossification of policy.

Mahbubani discusses the short comings of great power and more specifically western diplomacy. Mahubani notes how western foreign policy has largely declined, not forming a coherent and consistent policy. He notes that western policy is often arbitrary and morally hypocritical. Mahbubani notes how western states often lecture about democratic values or liberalist perspectives, but often disregard these pragmatically or work to weaken international institutions. Mahbubani also notes how a groupthink about China is formed, where many American thinkers, and smart ones, approach China from a hostile perspective. Mahbubani compares and equates this to the pre second Iraq war consensus. Throughout the book Mahbubani recounts similar experiences, and these in turn shape his worldview.

Mahbubani argues for a more pragmatic foreign policy based primarily on pragmatism rather than dogmatic concerns and one that is at its core consistent. Mahbubani notes how ASEAN diplomats slowly build consensus whereas western diplomats often focus on single breakthroughs. He also notes how his success in the United nations was due to his focus on building relations with African and non-aligned countries, which proved critical as these countries viewed themselves as ignored or marginalized by western powers.

His early years as a Sindhi minority in newly independent Singapore instilled both admiration for Western meritocratic ideals that offered escape from ethnic marginalization and skepticism of Western claims to moral superiority given colonialism's recent wounds. His late experience in life such as in academia and diplomacy caused him to gradually become disillusioned. Further developments such as the advancement of the Asian tiger economies while the west was embroiled in economic crises further cemented his changing outlook and hence approach to diplomacy.

# IV. Connections to Course Material

This book connects to the course content Mahbubani's memoir directly reinforces several core concepts, but also leaves out a few critical ones. Connected to our class is how Mahbubani discusses and demonstrates how multilateral diplomacy functions, personal relationships in statecraft, inter-great power interactions and international diplomacy. On the other hand, Mahbubani gives a distinct approach to the readings, which are written from a very western perspective and provide another lens in viewing diplomacy and geopolitical trends as previously discussed.

# V. Critical Assessment and Conclusion

## A. Strengths of Mahbubani's Approach

Mahbubani's greatest strength is his authenticity, allowing him to serve as an authentic interpreter in a diplomatic context. Unlike many western politicians, commentators or diplomats, Mahubani is capable of bringing a distinct viewpoint and employ it effectively in diplomacy. Mahbubani combines his Indian-Sinhi heritage, western education and diverse upbringing to best execute diplomatic strategies. His memoir shows the strength of this approach in his experiences with ASEAN and the UN. This means he is able to balance numerous civilizatonal-political outputs and translate them effectively for consensus building.

Furthermore, Mahbubani's strength was intellectual, applying both intellectual power with practical and effective skills and experience. This is a rare combination and allowed him to success where he otherwise may not have. This has allowed him to make accurate judgment calls, such as recognizing the flaws in the "end of history thesis" or predicting Asias rise before it was readily apparent. Mahbubani was a veracious reader in his youth, and this is a key strength of him and any aspiring diplomat.

## B. Limitations and Blind Spots

These limitations are both plainly apparent, but also some of these are my own personal judgment calls. While Mahbubani's civilization fluency is definitely one of his strongest advantages, he still remains an outsider to western values. There is nothing wrong with this, but it does limit and contextual some of his claims and ideas. I do believe to some degree that he may be slightly over optimistic about the "Asian century". While many Asian states have made great progress, it ultimately remain to be seen if past growth rates can be extrapolated to the future.

Furthermore, Mahbubani's unique experience while a strength is a double edged swords. It is not clear if his (and by extension) Singapore's unique story can be extrapolated to other and especially larger states or those with as longer history (and corresponding historical baggage). In addition to this, Singapore remains at best (and generously) an "illiberal democracy". I believe while Mahbubani is right to call out western hypocrisy, and not a different interpretation of human rights, I do believe that simultaneously he may underestimate the importance or even appeal of democratic western values.

## C. Overall Assessment

Mahbubani's story resonates with my on a personal level, having a diverse background and experience he charts a way to leverage these strengths in a diplomatic context. His willingness to be undiplomatic and speak uncomfortable truths reminds me that our value often lies precisely in our ability to see and articulate what those comfortable within single systems cannot perceive. Systems in which uncomfortable questions

are not asked become stagnant and eventually fail. Having the power to view a system (in this case diplomatically) from multiple angles can allow us to develop more robust approaches.

The memoirs most memorable take away is Mahbubani's inter cultural skills, being able to bridge different beliefs, peoples, cultures and backgrounds and the advantages this provides for diplomacy. I also quite liked his pragmatic idealism and challenge of wester orthodoxy in foreign policy. I found it to be quite refreshing in terms of a new perspective and approach. I also found that learning form his personal individual mistakes was quite useful, as future kjcan avoid the pitfalls Mahbubani had.

## Works Cited

Mahbubani, Kishore. Living the Asian Century: An Undiplomatic Memoir. PublicAffairs, 2024.